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Thoughts on the Workplace as a Masculinity Contest

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We consider how the research featured in this special issue reveals the deeply emotional nature of men's gender-identity constructions at work: men qua men feeling threatened and insecure and thus compelled to prove their manliness in survival-of-the-fittest competitions. These papers locate this behavior not in individual bad actors nor in men's supposed biological drives, but rather in the organizational norms and practices that foster masculinity contests. We offer possible ways forward for organizational practice and policy aimed at eliminating masculinity contest cultures and their negative effects.

Economists think of the workplace as the repository of rationality: for centuries, they have assumed the workplace to be an emotionless arena, ruled by logic and not the passions. Individual rational actors seek to maximize profits in a marketplace simultaneously coherent and chaotic, organized and frenzied. Booms and busts, bubbles and bursts, bulls and bears—these are the alliterative materials of which economies are made.

In this view, if the marketplace had a “gender,” it would be normatively masculine: traditionally masculine values, such as rationality and competitiveness, drive these individual rational profit-maximizers toward a collective rationality. Of course, sociologists have long understood the “non-rational foundations of the contract,” as Durkheim so famously put it. But economists have remained steadfast in their commitment to Lockean individual rationality and the Smithian notion that all these individual rationalities add up to one big rational, efficient, and productive system.

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What a refreshing surprise, then, to read these papers and see just how flooded with emotion is the workplace! Gender scholars have long understood that men as well as women “do gender”: we construct our gender identities in social interactions that take place in contexts saturated with cultural messages about what it means to be a man or woman. And we’ve long recognized how the workplace, as one such context, is itself gendered—in its rules and hierarchies, its evaluations of performances, its demands for commitment to work above family, all of which give men who manage to fit conventional masculine norms a leg up. Rarely, however, have we delved as deeply as this set of papers does into the complexity of emotions, motives, and expectations that accompany men’s “gender doings” at work.

In these papers, we see that just as workplaces’ rational profit-maximizer side is masculine gendered, so too is its presumed-rational emotion-minimizer side: masculinity contest cultures are predicated—and prey—on men’s insecurity, all the while setting up a competition whose purpose is to keep these feelings at bay. In masculinity contest cultures, men take great pains to demonstrate their fit with conventional masculine images in order to prove their worth as workers and as men. As Ely and Meyerson (2010: 6) have noted:

At the extreme, masculinity has been described as an identity men strive to achieve by beating “lesser men” in contests of manhood (Kerfoot & Knights, 1993: 672); those seeking it as “preoccupied with . . . differentiating self by out-performing others [and] validating self by negating others” (Barrett, 1996: 141); and those attaining it as “never secure,” dependent on others’ confirmation “to affirm and reaffirm to themselves and to others who and what they are” (Barrett, 1996: 141; see also Bird, 1996; Messner, 2005). Although extreme, these characterizations highlight how a man’s efforts to *prove* his manliness—to himself and to others—are as central to enacting a masculine identity as the particular traits he displays.

In their introduction to this special issue, Jennifer Berdahl and colleagues present the theoretical framework that informs these papers, distinguishing this volume from other collections on this topic by emphasizing this very point: that masculinity is problematic not only because organizations reward those who perform masculinity but, more importantly, because they reward those who outperform others in masculinity. Accordingly, these papers do not locate the problem of masculinity in a few “bad men” or in the supposed biological drives of men more generally or in the demands of masculine-gendered jobs; rather, they locate the problem in the workplace cultures that foster masculinity contests—the organizational norms and practices that encourage and reward survival-of-the-fittest competition where fit is defined by adherence to conventional masculine norms. In short, organizations’ masculinity contest cultures are broader than the gendered individuals who inhabit them and deeper than any single policy could change.

As part of the collaborative research project from which these papers are drawn, Peter Glick, Jennifer Berdahl, and Natalya Alonso created a Masculinity Contest Culture (MCC) scale to assess the extent to which a work environment is

saturated with these sorts of norms and practices. Its four measures are (1) show no weakness, (2) strength and stamina, (3) put work first, and (4) “dog eat dog” mentality. Extensive analyses across two studies demonstrate the scale’s reliability and construct validity and show that masculinity contest norms harm men as well as women. Moreover, these norms go hand-in-hand with other negative organizational dynamics, such as toxic leadership and lack of psychological safety. Several papers in this volume employ this scale, further explicating how masculinity contest cultures affect people and workplaces and demonstrating the scale’s value as a key measure for use in organizational research on masculinity.

Masculinity contests are based on binary thinking—a zero-sum mentality that infects all aspects and strata of the workplace, as Sophie Kuchynka and her colleagues show. Their twin studies find that this organizational culture leads to stronger biases against women and that when men experience threats to their gender identity (and their superiority), they are more likely to take it out ideologically on women by reducing their support for gender-equal policies.

These effects are unfortunate, of course, but also to be expected. For example, we know from previous research that when men perceive threats to their masculinity, they are also more likely to sexually harass women colleagues because working women represent such a threat (Maass, Cadinu, Guarnieri, & Grasselli, 2003; Siebler, Sabelus, & Bohner, 2008).

But Natalya Alonso’s paper reveals further negative effects: when men’s gender identity is threatened, they also engage in more sexual harassment of men. These findings are consistent with tests of the MCC scale’s convergent validity, which reveal strong correlations between the scale and reports of workplace sexual harassment for both women and men. Taken together, these studies suggest that in masculinity contest workplaces, where experiencing masculinity threats is endemic, we can expect to see sharper divisions, not only between women and men, but also among men. In these workplaces, hierarchies of masculinity are likely to replace collegial solidarity.

Masculinity contest cultures not only affect workers; they are also a breeding ground for toxic leadership. The paper by Kenneth Matos, Mandy O’Neill, and Xue Lei shows how leaders are more abusive toward their subordinates in organizations with masculinity contest cultures and how abusive leadership in turn is associated with higher levels of employee stress, work–life conflict, and turnover intentions. Unexpectedly, however, they also find that working for a toxic manager in a masculinity contest culture is associated with greater work engagement and job meaning for men (but not for women), suggesting that men, in some circumstances, may find the prospect of winning masculine status so seductive that they are willing to sacrifice their wellbeing for opportunities to enter the contest.

According to Christin Munsch and her colleagues, a dynamic they call “pluralistic ignorance” perpetuates this type of organizational culture. Bystanders who find behaviors in masculinity contest cultures objectionable believe they cannot

challenge the cultural norms that permit such behaviors because they assume no one else finds them problematic. Thus, a culture of silence surrounds the most egregious behaviors, allowing them to persist and further reinforcing their presumed acceptability.

But how does such an organizational culture come to define the workplace in the first place? One way, according to previous research, is via the gender associated with the occupations that make up the organization's workforce. Occupations thought to be masculine require attributes that men ideally possess and that women purportedly lack. Organizations import these occupational norms, conflating prescriptive masculine stereotypes with the skills required to do the job and defining competence in part by how well a job incumbent fits the desired masculine image (e.g., Acker, 1990; Eagly & Carli, 2007; Kolb, Fletcher, Meyerson, Merrill-Sands, & Ely, 2003; Martin, 2003). The workplace thus becomes a proving ground for masculinity as workers seek to demonstrate their competence (Ely & Meyerson, 2010).

In their careful comparative analysis of three male-dominated occupations—consultants, firefighters, and business executives—Erin Reid, Mandy O'Neill, and Mary Blair-Loy put a finer point on this analysis, showing that the emergence of a volatile masculinity contest in masculine-gendered occupations is neither inevitable nor uniform. Drawing on the authors' respective case studies, this article shows how an occupation's social class interacts with other occupational features—how, when, and what type of work is done—shaping behavioral norms for men and the operation of masculinity contest cultures more generally.

In an in-depth study of another masculine occupation—policing—Shannon Rawski and Angela Workman-Stark show how the masculinity contest culture operates in a Canadian policing organization and speculate about what can be done to mitigate it. Drawing on the sexual harassment and diversity training literature, this article points to a paradox that would seem to call into question the efficacy of training interventions: the organizations that need the intervention the most contain the very conditions—tolerance of ethical breaches, normalization of negative behaviors, cynicism—that are most likely to undermine employees' motivation to learn and change. To address this paradox, this article recommends that training interventions offer participants different ways of making sense of negative behavior and more positive roles to be taken up in relation to it, while also acknowledging that the same behavior can easily be interpreted differently by different people.

This proposed intervention notwithstanding, the deeply entrenched nature of masculinity contest cultures all too often leads to a kind of defeatist resignation. "Oh well, nothing we can do about it," or the more forgiving, "Boys will be boys," are common refrains.

We urge a more proactive stance and offer two possible routes to change. The first is an "outside-in" approach in which shifts in the broader culture are

leveraged to transform the discourse—and ultimately, the behavior—taking place inside of companies. Leaders using the #MeToo movement’s public consciousness-raising as an opportunity to catalyze such discussions are an example. By women speaking out in solidarity with one another and challenging the business-as-usual “normality” of sexual harassment in the workplace, the rules of organizational behavior, and especially the rules governing how men treat women, are changing in real time. The *Mad Men* era, when executives’ sexual access to the proverbial secretarial pool was de rigueur—a dynamic that turns out to be far more prevalent across business and the professions today than many ever imagined—may finally be coming to an end. We are hopeful that the serious media attention #MeToo has received might spur long-overdue conversations inside companies about what is acceptable workplace behavior and what is not. The success of this strategy, however, rests on organizations equipping employees with the capacity to have these difficult conversations and to give and receive feedback constructively and nondefensively.

A second course of action is an “inside-out” strategy that starts with organizational leaders developing an aspirational vision for their company—one that is widely understood as vital to advancing the company’s well-being and that necessitates broad-based culture change (see Ely & Meyerson, 2010). People find compelling visions that involve contributing to the well-being of the whole because they satisfy a basic human need for relatedness (Baumeister & Leary, 1995; Deci & Ryan, 2000; Sheldon, Ryan, Deci, & Kasser, 2004; for a review, see Podolny, Khurana, & Hill-Popper, 2005). In this approach, leaders undertake a deep reflection-and-learning process in which they uncover how norms and practices stemming from the organization’s culture, including its masculinity contest culture, drive unproductive behaviors that ultimately undermine their vision. They see how masculinity contest cultures insidiously and surreptitiously supplant collective well-being goals with the goal of proving one’s masculine image. To change the masculinity contest culture thus involves reorienting men away from the goal of proving masculinity and toward goals that are more compelling, holding them accountable in their workplace interactions to a set of standards that are aligned with such goals, and providing a work environment that is sufficiently psychologically safe that men are willing to risk their self-image in order to accomplish these higher-priority goals. In this way, “the organization loosens the broader culture’s grip on how men enact maleness at work, releasing them to *undo gender*” (Ely & Meyerson, 2010: 27, emphasis added).

We began this essay noting how masculinity contest cultures are shot through with emotion—men *qua* men feeling threatened and insecure and thus compelled to prove their manliness. Indeed, one of the great ironies of business is that ostensibly rational economic men pursuing their supposed individual interests does not lead to greater collective rationality, but rather, to a well of anxiety and fear that actually undermines it.

At the end of his masterpiece, *The Protestant Ethic and The Spirit of Capitalism*, the great sociologist Max Weber (1974) warned that the pursuit of rationality would imprison us in an “iron cage.” As he wrote in the book’s final pages, “[i]n the field of its highest development, in the United States, the pursuit of wealth, stripped of its religious and ethical meaning, tends to become associated with purely mundane passions, which often actually give it the character of sport.”

The global economy and the individual organizational actors in its various marketplaces are too important to be captured by a metaphor drawn from a spectacle of entertainment. The contest is a trap: so long as it exists, men are likely to compete. Organizations that enable men to risk their masculine image in service of advancing more worthwhile goals will gradually make such contests obsolete.

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